

What is an AO?

An 'AO' is a plant export Authorised Officer.

AOs are individuals, trained and assessed by us and are authorised as Australian Government officials (public officials) under the Export Control Act 2020 (the Act). An AO is able to perform a range of export functions on behalf of the Department of Agriculture, Fisheries and Forestry.

AOs play an important role in ensuring the biosecurity risk free, safe and trusted export of a variety of commodities, which helps maintain Australia's reputation as a trusted exporter of quality goods.

An AO may be a Commonwealth, State or Territory government officer, or a third-party individual.

Examples of third-party AOs include, but are not limited to:

- employee linked to a specific business
- employee of a registered establishment
- employee of an exporter
- self-employed individual/sole traders.

The Departmental Policy: Management of third-party plant exports authorised officers describes the policy relating to the regulation of third-party plant export AOs.

Download documents

- [Departmental Policy: Management of third-party plant exports authorised officers \(PDF 388 KB\)](#)
- [Departmental Policy: Management of third-party plant exports authorised officers \(DOCX 120 KB\)](#)

If you have difficulty accessing these files, visit [web accessibility](#) for assistance.

I was previously an AO, can my authorisation be reinstated?

Persons who were previously authorised as a plant export AO, but either allowed their authorisation to expire or withdrew from the AO model may be able to have their authorisation reinstated.

For more information, refer to [Reinstatement of expired AOs](#).

I'm interested in becoming an AO, where do I start?

Step-by-step guide to becoming an Australian plant export AO

To become an Australian plant export AO, a few steps must be completed.

So, you want to become an AO? Great! Now let's determine what job functions you will perform in your workplace.

Follow the links below to find out about what products each job function covers, as well as the training and assessment required to gain your authorisation.

You have successfully completed the first step of the AO candidate journey through choosing your job functions. The next step is application.

You must submit an AO application online through the [Plant Export Management System \(PEMS\)](#).

Detailed instructions for lodging a new AO application in PEMS can be found in the Work Instruction: Applying to become an Authorised Officer using the Plant Exports Management System. You must complete all steps of this work instruction to successfully apply.

Download documents

- [Work Instruction: Applying to become an Authorised Officer using the Plant Exports Management System \(PDF 3.8 MB\)](#)
- [Work Instruction: Applying to become an Authorised Officer using the Plant Exports Management System \(DOCX 6.3 MB\)](#)

If you have difficulty accessing these files, visit [web accessibility](#) for assistance.

In the application process, you must:

- provide 100 points of identification; with at least one piece of primary identification and one containing a photograph
- provide a National Police Check (no more than 12 months old)
- choose your job functions (fees apply).

Once your application has been approved, you will proceed to the next step.

How do I know if my PEMS registration has been received?

If you have successfully requested the 'Authorized Officer' role in PEMS following the Work Instruction: Applying to become an Authorised Officer using the Plant Exports Management System you will receive an email from PlantExportTraining@aff.gov.au within 10 business days notifying you that your access request has been accepted.

How do I know if my application has been received?

If you have successfully submitted your application following the Work Instruction: Applying to become an Authorised Officer using the Plant Exports Management System you will receive an email from donotreply@aff.gov.au notifying you that your application has been received and that the AO Program will process your application within 15 business days. Your application status will also change from Active to Submitted within PEMS.

Are there any pre-requisites?

There are no pre-requisites for becoming an AO however, pre-requisites may apply for certain job functions. More information can be found on the [Job functions for Authorised Officers](#) webpage.

Grain Storage Assets and Management Standard (GSAMS) Scheme

The department recognises the [Grain Storage Assets and Management Standard](#) (GSAMS) as an industry framework that supports export requirements. Together, GSAMS and its assurance framework are known as the Grain Storage Assets and Management Standard Scheme.

If you work at an GSAMS approved registered establishment (RE), you can apply for the GSAMS equivalent of the job functions GSEP4001, PGG3001 or ECI3001.

For further information refer to the Grain Storage Assets and Management Standard (GSAMS) Scheme for grain exports webpage.

Cost

You must pay an application fee of \$328 through PEMS.

Note: These fees are correct from 1 July 2026 to 30 June 2027, but may change after this time. Further information about AO [fees and charges](#) is available on the department's website.

How long will it take to become an AO?

The process to become an AO involves self-paced learning and will therefore vary from person to person. We recommend allowing a minimum of 3–6 months from when your completed application is received.

Am I required to be an Australian Citizen in order to become an AO?

It is not a requirement to be an Australia citizen in order to become an AO; however, you must be able to obtain an Australian National Police Check.

Is an AO a government official?

When undertaking the functions, they are authorised for under the Act, AOs are regarded as Australian Government officials (public officials), however they are not considered employees of the Australian Government.

What conditions apply to an AO?

An AO must:

- behave honestly, and with integrity and impartiality

- act with care and diligence
- treat everyone with respect and courtesy, and without harassment
- only exercise powers and functions for which they have been authorised
- comply with all applicable Australian laws
- comply with any lawful and reasonable direction given by someone in the Commonwealth who has authority to give the direction
- comply with all relevant instructional material published by the Commonwealth
- maintain currency of skills by attending training as directed by the Commonwealth
- be available for assurance and audit visits by the Commonwealth
- notify the Commonwealth of any observed fraudulent practices or the provision of false and misleading information in relation to the export of plants and plant products from Australia
- notify the Commonwealth of any persons applying undue influence, harassment or offers of bribery
- ensure the payment of all debts due to the Commonwealth
- maintain correct contact details and notify the Commonwealth of any change in circumstances, including
 - conflicts of interest that may arise or have arisen
 - conviction of an offence under Commonwealth, State or Territory law
 - an order to pay a pecuniary penalty
 - the existence of outstanding debts due to the Commonwealth
 - a change in the conditions which permit the AO to work in Australia.
- behave in a way that upholds the integrity and good reputation of the Commonwealth and do not do anything that would cause harm to the Commonwealth's interests or reputation
- comply with the Privacy Act 1988, including protecting and not inappropriately using or disclosing commercial in confidence information of clients and businesses.

As public officials, AOs fall under the jurisdiction of the National Anti-Corruption Commission Act 2022. Under the National Anti-Corruption Commission Act 2022, the National Anti-Corruption Commission (NACC) is responsible for detecting, investigating, and reporting on serious or systemic 'corrupt conduct' in the public sector. This means that AOs who engage in corrupt conduct may be investigated by the NACC. The NACC is also able to investigate any person, even if they are not a public official, if that person does something that might cause an AO to carry out their role in a dishonest or biased way.

Some examples of 'corrupt conduct' can include:

- Breach of public trust – arises when an AO exercises official powers for an improper purpose, or in a way that goes against the purpose for which the powers were authorised.
- Abuse of office – when an AO engages in improper acts or omissions knowing the conduct is improper. These acts or behaviours have the intention to gain a benefit for themselves, or others, or to cause a detriment to another person.
- Misuse of information – when an AO, or former AO, does something that involves misuse of information or documents that they have or had access to because of their role.

- Causing, or attempting to cause, a public official to behave dishonestly or in a biased way – when a person does something that does, or could, cause an AO to behave dishonestly or show bias when exercising their official functions, powers, or duties.

Who covers injury and liability for AOs?

Third party AOs are covered by their company's workers' compensation insurance. The department's insurer does not cover third party AOs, as they are not employed under the department's Enterprise Agreement.

For liability, the Act protects AOs from civil action if they carry out their duties in good faith. However, if a third party AO intentionally or recklessly fails to perform their duties, they may be held personally liable for any losses caused.

What does 'fit and proper person' mean?

A fit and proper person is someone who can demonstrate to the department that they are suitable to act as an AO on behalf of the Australian Government. A fit and proper person assessment will include, but is not limited to, an analysis of your National Police Check.

When an application is received, AO candidates are sent a Fit and Proper Person Questionnaire to complete. If it has been more than 15 business days since you received confirmation that your application has been received and you have not yet received an email containing the questionnaire, please email PlantExportTraining@aff.gov.au.

How do I know if my Fit and Proper Person Questionnaire was received?

You will receive an email from PlantExportTraining@aff.gov.au within 10 business days notifying you that your application has been sent to the Fit and Proper Person team to undergo a Fit and Proper Person evaluation.

How long does the Fit and Proper Person test take?

The fit and proper person test may take up to 60 business days to complete.

Can I complete my eLearning, training and assessment before the Fit and Proper Person test is completed?

You can complete your eLearning, training and assessment before the Fit and Proper Person test is completed. However, you cannot be authorised as an AO unless you are found to be fit and proper.

This means that if you choose to pay for and complete eLearning, training and assessment, you accept that you may not be authorised as an AO if you do not meet this requirement.

If you are found not to be fit and proper and are not authorised, the department will not refund any fees for eLearning, training or assessment that has already been provided. You can only get a refund if the services were not delivered.

If I have a conflict of interest, will I be automatically ineligible?

You must declare on your application any interests, pecuniary or otherwise, that conflict or could conflict with your proper performance of functions or exercise of powers as an AO.

While avoiding a conflict is best, it is not always practical. Having a conflict of interests will not automatically exclude an applicant from being authorised as an AO. Some examples of conflicts of interest and possible ways they could be managed are provided below. If you are not sure if your situation involves a conflict of interest, please declare it and we will consider it.

Potential conflicts of interest

Employee of company where you will be an AO

Direct or indirect financial interest as owner, director or owner of shares in an establishment (including employees involved in employee ownership schemes)

Family/emotional relationship to the owners or management of an establishment

Employed in management or control of the establishment.

How the conflict may be managed

We will audit and verify your activities to ensure you are performing functions and exercising your powers as an AO appropriately.

You will be subject to a fit and proper person test, which will take into account those interests. If you are then authorised as an AO, your performance may be subject to more intensive scrutiny under our audit and verification regime.

You may be required to sell or relinquish your interest in the establishment.

You will be subject to a fit and proper person test, which will take into account those interests.

If you are authorised as an AO, your performance may be subject to more intensive scrutiny under our audit and verification regime.

As a condition of your authorisation you may be directed not to perform functions or exercise your powers as an AO for the establishment where you have a family/emotional relationship to the owners of management.

You will be subject to a fit and proper person test, which will take into account those interests.

If you are authorised as an AO, your performance may be subject to more intensive scrutiny under our audit and verification regime.

As a condition of your authorisation you may be directed not to perform functions or exercise your powers as an AO for the establishment where you are employed in management or control.

Working in a number of different establishments of the same type may be considered a conflict of interest. For example, if the AO's principal employer is a business competitor of the establishment where the AO is carrying out an assessment, there may be a perception that the AO would not be impartial.

Employment with another establishment of the same type as the establishment where the applicant would like to carry out AO duties.

As a condition of your authorisation you may be directed to disclose this interest to the management of all establishments where you intend to work.

If you are authorised as an AO, your performance may be subject to more intensive scrutiny under our audit and verification regime to ensure these conflicts are being managed.

It is worth noting that in this situation the AO is also bound by the ethical and privacy obligations embodied in the Privacy Act 1988 and any associated penalty regimes.

Volunteer work, political or religious views or opinions

In some cases, applicants may perceive that unpaid work, or political views may result in conflicts of interest with their role as AOs. For example, an applicant may be an active member of a community group opposed to genetically modified organisms or the use of particular agricultural chemicals.

As a condition of your authorisation, you may be directed not to perform functions or exercise your powers as an AO in relation to particular types of products or in particular locations.

If I have a criminal record, will I be automatically ineligible?

A criminal conviction or pending charge will not automatically exclude an applicant from being authorised as an AO. Nonetheless, the department may be concerned that a particular charge or conviction reflects that applicant's fitness to perform the services required or may affect their integrity and the reputation of the department.

You have successfully completed the first 2 steps of the AO candidate journey. The next step is eLearning.

You must request access to the eLearning online through PEMS.

Instructions for requesting access to the eLearning in PEMS can be found in the Work Instruction: Requesting Authorised Officer eLearning using the Plant Exports Management System. You must complete all steps of this work instruction to successfully apply.

Download documents

- Work Instruction: Requesting Authorised Officer eLearning using the Plant Exports Management System (PDF)
- Work Instruction: Requesting Authorised Officer eLearning using the Plant Exports Management System (DOC)

If you have difficulty accessing these files, visit [web accessibility](#) for assistance.

We will create an account for you and enrol you into the relevant eLearning programs. You will receive email notification of enrolment from the department's learning management system – Learnhub – with a link to the log in page.

The eLearning programs are designed to be informative and self-paced learning products that are mandatory in preparing you for authorisation in your chosen job functions. You are required to read and understand each page and complete all quizzes and knowledge assessments.

Is the eLearning mandatory?

eLearning is mandatory and must be completed prior to requesting assessment.

The PEMS video tutorials are not mandatory. These are designed to assist you with completing inspection records in PEMS and will always show as incomplete on your Learnhub profile.

How do I know if I've completed my eLearning?

If you are unsure whether you have completed your eLearning, you can login to your Learnhub account and select My Learning > Enrolments. If any programs or courses are listed, you have not yet completed your eLearning.

Is there prior learning recognition for an applicant that has been working as an inspector for a number of years?

There is no recognition of prior learning in place. Every AO candidate must complete the training.

Cost

To gain access to the eLearning program, you'll need to pay a \$130 fee through PEMS.

Note: These fees are correct from 1 July 2026 to 30 June 2027, but may change after this time. Further information about AO [fees and charges](#) is available on the department's website.

You have successfully completed the first 3 steps of the AO candidate journey. The next step is facilitated training.

Facilitated training is mandatory for all job functions.

This training equips you with further skills and knowledge required to competently carry out your job functions, in accordance with relevant legislative requirements.

Although completion of the relevant eLearning programs for each job function is not a pre-requisite for facilitated training, it is recommended that you complete your eLearning before requesting facilitated training.

Detailed instructions on requesting facilitated training through PEMS can be found in the Work Instruction: Requesting Authorised Officer training using the Plant Exports Management System. You must complete all steps of this work instruction to successfully request training.

Download documents

- [Work Instruction: Requesting Authorised Officer training using the Plant Exports Management System \(PDF 1.2 MB\)](#)
- [Work Instruction: Requesting Authorised Officer training using the Plant Exports Management System \(DOCX 1.7 MB\)](#)

If you have difficulty accessing these files, visit [web accessibility](#) for assistance.

Cost

To request training, you'll need to pay a \$216 training fee through PEMS for each job function.

Note: These fees are correct from 1 July 2026 to 30 June 2027, but may change after this time. Further information about AO [fees and charges](#) is available on the department's website.

What if I applied under the Grain Storage Assets and Management Standard (GSAMS) Scheme?

If you applied as part of the GSAMS Scheme, you can choose to be trained by the department or by industry.

If industry training is chosen, you may apply to have the department's training fee waived.

All AOs must still complete the mandatory eLearning and pass an assessment.

For further information refer to the [Grain Storage Assets and Management Standard \(GSAMS\) Scheme](#) for grain exports webpage.

How do I know if my training request has been received?

If you are unsure whether your training request has been received, login to your PEMS account and select the Training & Assessment tab. If you have requested training your Status should be listed as 'Paid' and your Job Groups – Status – Date should be showing as 'Training Requested'. If this is not the case, you will need to follow the Work Instruction: Requesting Authorised Officer training using the Plant Exports Management System to request training.

When will I receive training?

We cannot provide an exact timeframe for how soon after submitting a request and paying the learning and assessment fee you will receive training. Generally speaking, a PEA should contact you about training within 1 month of receiving payment.

If you do not hear anything within this timeframe, and you have confirmed that your Status is listed as 'Paid' and your Job Groups – Status – Date is showing as 'Training Requested', email PlantExportTraining@aff.gov.au.

What will the training cover?

Training will cover how to:

- work effectively in an export environment
- conduct pre-inspection tasks
- prepare to supervise applicable phytosanitary treatments
- conduct flowpath inspection tasks
- identify and apply the correct sampling rates and inspection techniques
- supervise the initiation of applicable phytosanitary treatments
- understand pest and contaminant tolerances
- pass the goods after an inspection
- verify the successful completion of applicable phytosanitary treatments
- fail the goods after an inspection
- correctly apply failed treatment procedures
- inspect a resubmitted consignment
- complete the applicable inspection/treatment record.

Further information about specific [job functions](#) is available on the department's website.

You have successfully completed the first 4 steps of the AO candidate journey. The next step is assessment.

AO candidates must participate in an assessment of competency against their chosen job functions. You will need to request an assessment through PEMS.

Detailed instructions on requesting assessment through PEMS can be found in the Work Instruction: Requesting an Authorised Officer assessment using the Plant Exports Management System. You must complete all steps of this work instruction to successfully request assessment.

Download documents

- Work Instruction: [Requesting an Authorised Officer assessment using the Plant Exports Management System \(PDF 969 KB\)](#)
- Work Instruction: [Requesting an Authorised Officer assessment using the Plant Exports Management System \(DOCX 1.17 MB\)](#)

If you have difficulty accessing these files, visit [web accessibility](#) for assistance.

What if I applied under the Grain Storage Assets and Management Standard (GSAMS) Scheme?

AOs who applied under the GSAMS Scheme are still required to pass a competency assessment delivered by the department. After you have completed industry training, you will need to request assessment through PEMS.

Where AO candidates are unable to demonstrate competency during assessment, the department will not recognise further training facilitated by industry. AO candidates will be required to undertake face-to-face training by the department. In this instance, training and assessment fees are charged in full.

For further information refer to the [Grain Storage Assets and Management Standard \(GSAMS\) Scheme](#) for grain exports webpage.

How do I know if my assessment request has been received?

If you are unsure whether your assessment request has been received, login to your PEMS account and select the Training & Assessment tab. If you have requested assessment your Status should be listed as 'Requested' and your Job Groups – Status – Date should be showing as 'Requested'. If this is not the case, you will need to follow the Work Instruction: Requesting Authorised Officer assessment using the Plant Exports Management System to request assessment.

When will I be assessed?

We cannot provide an exact timeframe for how soon after submitting a request you will be assessed. Generally speaking, a PEA should contact you about assessment within 1 month of receiving your assessment request.

If you do not hear anything within this timeframe, and you have confirmed that your Status is listed as 'Requested' and your Job Groups – Status – Date is showing as 'Requested', email PlantExportTraining@aff.gov.au.

How will I be assessed?

Information about what to expect during assessment can be found in the [job function](#) descriptions.

What happens if I fail the assessment?

If you receive an assessment result of Not Yet Competent Level 2 (NYC2), you will be able to attend a partial reassessment in the areas that were deemed not yet competent at a later date.

If you receive an assessment result of Not Yet Competent Level 1 (NYC1), you will need to receive additional training prior to being eligible for a full reassessment.

Cost

To request assessment, you'll need to pay a \$216 assessment fee through PEMS for each job function.

If you receive an assessment result of NYC1, additional training and assessment is required and you'll need to pay the training and assessment fees again through PEMS.

Note: These fees are correct from 1 July 2026 to 30 June 2027, but may change after this time. Further information about AO [fees and charges](#) is available on the department's website.

When will I be able to undertake inspections?

Once you have received your instrument of authorisation you will be authorised as a plant export AO and be able to perform inspections that you are authorised for.

You have successfully completed the first 5 steps of the AO candidate journey. The next step is authorisation.

Once your assessment result has been verified, you must pay an approval fee and acknowledge that you have read and understood the obligations placed on you as an AO.

Once you have done this, you will be able to request your Instrument of Authorisation (IoA) through PEMS.

Detailed instructions on how to request your IoA through PEMS can be found in the Work Instruction: Requesting an AO Instrument of Authorisation using the Plant Exports Management System. You must complete all steps of this work instruction to successfully request your IoA.

Download documents

- [Work Instruction: Requesting an Instrument of Authorisation using the Plant Exports Management System \(PDF 1.13 MB\)](#)
- [Work Instruction: Requesting an Instrument of Authorisation using the Plant Exports Management System \(DOCX 2.42 MB\)](#)

If you have difficulty accessing these files, visit [web accessibility](#) for assistance.

When will my IoA be available in PEMS?

Your IoA will be generated in PEMS within 24 hours of paying the approval fee. You will also be assigned the relevant job function/s you require to complete inspections.

You can check whether you have paid the approval fee by logging into your PEMS account and opening your Authorisation tab. If the option to 'Pay Now' is showing, you have not paid your approval fee; follow the steps in the Work Instruction: Requesting an Instrument of Authorisation using the Plant Exports Management System to pay this fee.

Cost

You must pay an instrument of Authorisation fee of \$328 through PEMS.

Note: These fees are correct from 1 July 2026 to 30 June 2027, but may change after this time. Further information about AO [fees and charges](#) is available on the department's website.

How long will I be authorised for?

Your job function authorisation is valid for a period of 2 years (except in the case of the Bulk Vessel Inspection job function which is valid only until the first prerequisite training/registration expires).

More information on reappointments can be found in [Step 10](#).

What are my responsibilities as an AO?

As an AO, you will have powers and sub-delegations under the Export Control Act 2020 and the Export Control (Plants and Plant Products) Rules 2021. Your instrument of authorisation will detail your specific delegations under the legislation.

When working as an AO, you are considered an Australian Government official. You must not exceed your powers and sub-delegations under the legislation.

As an AO, depending on your powers and sub-delegations under the legislation, you may be legally required to make sure that:

- empty containers and/or vessel holds meet required standards.
- prescribed goods (plants and plant products) exported from Australia comply with the requirements of the plant rules.
- relevant treatments are conducted in a way that meets the required standards.

Regional Assurance Manager (RAM) support

You will receive ongoing support throughout your authorisation from your local Regional Assurance Manager (RAM).

A RAM is part of a regionally based team providing support to Plant Export AOs and their employers (clients). RAMs establish and maintain effective and productive relationships with their clients to ensure understanding of and adherence to plant export policies. RAMs do this through a number of regular on-site visits.

Once you are authorised, you can expect your local RAM to be in touch to organise your post-assessment visit.

Your RAM will be contactable throughout your authorisation and will make regular contact with you.

You can find all the information you need, regarding RAMS and their visits, by visiting the [RAM webpage](#).

Note: A RAM visit is not an audit.

AO Hotline

As an AO, you will also have access to the Authorised Officer Hotline on [1800 851 305](#).

You can call the hotline at any time if you need assistance with an inspection, your authorisation, or if you have a general plant export query.

Plant Export Training mailbox

As an AO, you will also have access to support via the Plant Export Training mailbox at PlantExportTraining@aff.gov.au.

You can email this mailbox at any time if you need assistance with an inspection, your authorisation, or if you have a general plant export query.

AOs must participate in regular auditing by the department. AOs are audited against performance standards outlined in the Reference: [Authorised officer audit performance standards](#). The Guideline: [Audit of plant export authorised officers](#) has been developed to ensure AOs are complying with the legislative and departmental requirements of their authorisation.

Audits are performed to provide assurance to stakeholders, which is important to both maintain and gain new market access. Audits are completed at least once every 12 months if no corrective action requests have previously been issued. Unannounced audits may be conducted at any time.

Cost

Fee for services rates apply to audits at \$47 per 15 minutes.

Note: Fees are correct from 1 July 2026 to 30 June 2027, but may change after this time. Further information about AO [fees and charges](#) is available on the department's website.

Audit process

Pre-examination

- The auditor will examine your export documentation.
- Errors will be discussed and addressed.

Meeting

- The auditor will meet you and describe the audit objective, scope and process.
- The auditor will work through the evaluation checklist.

Demonstration

- You will be asked to demonstrate an export activity or task.
- You will be asked questions.

Conclusion

- An exit meeting will be conducted at the conclusion of the audit.
- You will be advised of the audit outcome and receive audit support.

What are the AO audit and performance standards?

The AO audit and performance standards outline the policy and process for the audit of plant export AOs. The Guideline: [Audit of plant export authorised officers](#) describes the framework of how and when AOs are audited by the department. The Reference: [Authorised officer audit performance standards](#) set the criteria against which AOs are assessed during audits in order to determine their compliance with legislative and departmental requirements.

How often will I be audited if I have been issued a non-compliance notice?

You will have an audit at least once every 12 months. However, if you were issued one or more non-compliance notices (NCN) previously, periodic audits may be performed every 3 to 6 months.

Will I be audited for all job functions?

You may be audited for all or some of your authorised job functions, depending on the number of job functions you are authorised for and whether or not you have been active (conducted export activities) in each job function. Where you are authorised for many job functions, you will be audited on only a select few using a hierarchy system that prioritises your more high-risk job functions for auditing.

Where you haven't used one or more of your authorised job functions since your authorisation or last audit, it will be excluded from the audit process.

What happens if I receive a negative result?

You will receive a non-compliance notice (NCN) for any non-compliance identified at your audit. When this occurs, you may be subject to more frequent audit timeframes of 3 to 6 months.

Sometimes re-training may be recommended to rectify a non-compliance. Negative audit outcomes warranting immediate attention may be referred to the delegate and (in cases of extreme or repeated non-compliances) may result in the revocation of your authorisation.

The department issues [Industry Advice Notices](#) (IANs) to inform its clients of changes and updates affecting the export of plants and plant products.

As an AO, you will be automatically registered to receive IANs relevant to your job functions. You can also check the [Industry Advice Notices](#) webpage for updates.

As an AO, you will also receive SMS notifications when IANs relevant to your job functions are released.

Your authorisation is valid for a period of 2 years (except in the case of the BVI3001: Export inspection of empty bulk vessels job function which is only valid until the first prerequisite training/registration expires).

You will receive emails generated by PEMS and pop-up messages will appear in your PEMS profile prior to your authorisation expiring. Whether you would like to continue your authorisation or not, you must follow the instructions that will be provided to you at the time.

Detailed instructions on how to request reappointment through PEMS can be found in the Work Instruction: Requesting reappointment using the Plant Exports Management System. You must complete all steps of this work instruction to successfully request reappointment.

Download documents

- [Work Instruction: Requesting reappointment using the Plant Exports Management System \(PDF 937 KB\)](#)
- [Work Instruction: Requesting reappointment using the Plant Exports Management System \(DOCX 1.68 MB\)](#)

If you have difficulty accessing these files, visit [web accessibility](#) for assistance.

You will receive a reappointment visit from a Regional Assurance Manager (RAM).

Once you have had your reappointment visit and you have paid your reappointment fee, you can request your new IoA through PEMS.

Cost

You must pay an approval fee of \$328 for your reappointment through PEMS. The reappointment approval fee is separate to the \$983 annual levy, which is charged each financial year on 1 July.

Note: These fees are correct from 1 July 2026 to 30 June 2027, but may change after this time. Further information about AO fees and charges is available on the department's website.

As an authorised AO there are things that we need you to do, as well as things you might need to do, to keep your authorisation up to date.

For example:

- paying the annual levy
- withdrawing from the AO model
- updating your personal information
- adding or removing job functions
- notifying us of a change in circumstance
- notifying us of any incidents.

Paying the annual levy

An annual levy of \$983 is charged each financial year on 1 July and applies to all AOs authorised for the financial year or part thereof. It is not pro rata. The annual levy covers costs associated with your authorisation that are not directly linked to a service. This is separate to the reappointment fee.

Non-payment of the annual levy by the due date is a contravention of the Act and may result in your authorisation being suspended or revoked.

The annual levy is payable through PEMS.

Detailed instructions on how to pay the annual levy through PEMS can be found in the Work Instruction: Paying the annual levy using the Plant Exports Management System. You must complete all steps of this work instruction to successfully pay the annual levy.

Download documents

- [Work Instruction: Paying the annual levy using the Plant Exports Management System \(PDF 894 KB\)](#)
- [Work Instruction: Paying the annual levy using the Plant Exports Management System \(DOCX 1.36 MB\)](#)

If you have difficulty accessing these files, visit [web accessibility](#) for assistance.

Note: These fees are correct from 1 July 2026 to 30 June 2027, but may change after this time. Further information about AO [fees and charges](#) is available on the department's website.

Withdrawing from the AO model

If at any point you wish to withdraw from the AO model, you must complete and submit an Authorised Officer Withdrawal Form to PlantExportTraining@aff.gov.au.

Download documents

If you have difficulty accessing these files, visit [web accessibility](#) for assistance.

Updating your personal information

It is important to keep your personal information up to date so that we can contact you about your authorisation.

You can update your contact details in PEMS at any time following the instructions in the Reference: [Plant Exports Management System \(PEMS\) Authorised Officer User Guide – Overview and General Functions](#) available on the Plant Export Operations Manual.

To update your name or date of birth email PlantExportTraining@aff.gov.au.

Adding job functions

You can add job functions, and job function attachments (commodity groups or inspection techniques), to your authorisation at any time following the instructions in the Work Instruction: Requesting additional job functions in the Plant Exports Management System. You must complete all steps of this work instruction to successfully add job functions.

Download documents

- [Work Instruction: Requesting additional job functions in the Plant Exports Management System \(PDF 818 KB\)](#)
- [Work Instruction: Requesting additional job functions in the Plant Exports Management System \(DOCX 2.06 MB\)](#)

If you have difficulty accessing these files, visit [web accessibility](#) for assistance.

Cost

You must pay an application to vary fee of \$328 through PEMS. You will also be required to pay for training and assessment per job function.

Note: These fees are correct from 1 July 2026 to 30 June 2027, but may change after this time. Further information about AO fees and charges is available on the department's website.

Removing job functions

To remove a job function or job function attachment/s (commodity group/s or inspection technique/s) from your authorisation email PlantExportTraining@aff.gov.au.

Notifying of a change in circumstance

It is important to notify us of any change in circumstance, including:

- conflicts of interest that may arise or have arisen
- a conviction of an offence under Commonwealth, State or Territory law
- pending criminal charges
- an order to pay a pecuniary penalty
- outstanding debts due to the Commonwealth
- a change in the conditions which permit the AO to work in Australia.

A failure to notify us of a change in circumstances is a contravention of the Act and may result in your authorisation being suspended or revoked.

You can update your conflict of interests and pending criminal charges details at any time following the instructions in the Reference: [Plant Exports Management System \(PEMS\) Authorised Officer User Guide – Overview and General Functions](#) available on the Plant Export Operations Manual.

To notify us of any other change of circumstance email PlantExportTraining@aff.gov.au.

Notify of an incident

It is important to notify us of any incidents, including:

- work health and safety
- persons applying undue influence, harassment or offers of bribery
- observed fraudulent practices or the provision of false and misleading formation in relation to the export of plants and plant products from Australia
- corrupt conduct.

To notify us of any incidents email PlantExportTraining@aff.gov.au.

Reports of corrupt conduct can also be made:

- via departmental channels of reporting – Integrity Hotline 1800 99 88 80 or integrity@aff.gov.au
- directly to the National Anti-Corruption Commission via their [website](#).

Note: When reporting actual or suspected corrupt conduct, AOs do not need to prove that corrupt conduct has occurred. AOS can also choose to remain anonymous. All reported allegations of corruption are taken seriously and treated confidentially.

A person who was previously authorised as a plant export AO, but either let that authorisation expire or withdrew from the AO model may have their authorisation reinstated if they can provide us with assurance that they have retained the skills and knowledge to be an AO.

To apply to have your authorisation reinstated you must complete and submit an Application to be reinstated as a plant export authorised officer to PlantExportTraining@aff.gov.au.

Download documents

- [Reference: Application to be reinstated as a plant export authorised officer \(PDF 439 KB\)](#)
- [Reference: Application to be reinstated as a plant export authorised officer \(DOCX 446 KB\)](#)

If you have difficulty accessing these files, visit [web accessibility](#) for assistance.

We understand that the process your staff member must follow in order to become an AO may seem daunting. This section will help you, as an employer adapt to the AO model for plant and plant product exports.

Below are the ways you can support your staff member through the AO process.

Understanding costs

Fees and charges apply to becoming an AO. All costs must be settled prior to a person being authorised as an AO.

An employer may choose to pay their employee's AO fees as an incentive; however, as an AO authorisation is an individual authorisation, payments must be made through the AO's personal profile in PEMS. Employers may choose to pay fees directly or to reimburse the AO for the cost.

Invoices are not issued for AO fees, but tax invoices will be automatically generated after payment is received.

Please note that credit/debit cards are the only payment option accepted through PEMS.

Understanding the AO candidate's responsibilities

It is the individual AO candidate's responsibility to take the steps required to achieve their authorisation as an AO. The company can only give support as needed.

The AO candidate must therefore:

- initiate the application process
- complete their eLearning
- request and participate in facilitated training
- request and participate in assessment.

The employers should allow their staff to decide if they want to become an AO, and when they are ready to be trained and assessed.

Supporting your staff member through the AO process

As the employer of an AO candidate, you will not be directly involved in the AO process, however you can support your staff member by:

- providing them access to a computer with an internet connection so they can complete their eLearning
- allowing them time to complete their eLearning during work hours
- giving them time off from work to attend facilitated training
- making sure they are ready for assessment and do not feel pressured to be assessed when they are not yet confident.

Continue to support your staff member after they are authorised as an AO

Employers should provide a supportive environment that allows:

- appropriate time and resources for AOs to learn and become confident in their role
- appropriate time and resources for AOs to perform their functions
- AOs to make independent export compliance decisions.

National Anti-Corruption Commission

It is important to note that, as public officials, AOs fall under the jurisdiction of the National Anti-Corruption Commission Act 2022. Under the National Anti-Corruption Commission Act 2022, the National Anti-Corruption Commission (NACC) is responsible for detecting, investigating, and reporting on serious or systemic corrupt conduct in the public sector.

The NACC can investigate any person, if that person does something that might cause an AO to carry out their role in a dishonest or biased way. As an employer of an AO, it is important that you understand the roles and responsibilities of AOs, and do not engage in conduct that interferes with the proper execution of their official functions, powers or duties.

Reports of corrupt conduct can be made:

- via departmental channels of reporting – Integrity Hotline [1800 99 88 80](tel:1800998880) or integrity@aff.gov.au
- directly to the National Anti-Corruption Commission via their [website](#).

Protected information

‘Protected information’ is information obtained under, or in accordance with, the Act. This includes information about an AO candidate or authorised AO.

Protected information can only be disclosed under certain circumstances. In accordance with the Act, we cannot disclose information about an AO candidate or authorised AO to their employer or company. For example, we cannot tell you if your employee has completed their eLearning or if they have paid their fees.

Under the Act, we can only disclose protected information to you if the AO candidate or authorised AO has given us permission to do so. This can be done via a 'Permission to disclose protected information form' submitted to PlantExportTraining@aff.gov.au.

Download documents

- [Permission to disclose protected information form \(PDF 266 KB\)](#)
- [Permission to disclose protected information form \(DOCX 150 KB\)](#)

If you have difficulty accessing these files, visit [web accessibility](#) for assistance.

Benefits to the company

By adopting the AO model, your company can benefit from:

- increased flexibility – you will have staff available to conduct export inspections when you need them
- consistent inspections – all AO candidates receive the same training and assessment, and follow the same instructional material
- ongoing support – your AOs will receive support visits from the department and can call the Authorised Officer Hotline on [1800 851 305](tel:1800851305) for assistance.

AO fees and charges are legislated in the:

- Export Control (Fees and Payments) Rules 2021
- Export Charges (Impositions—General) Regulations 2021

You will find below a table outlining fees associated with becoming an AO and maintaining that authorisation. Fees and charges are also addressed under the applicable sections in the AO process of this webpage.

Total fee breakdown

Fee type	Amount
AO application	\$328 per application
eLearning	\$130 one off
Training	\$216 per job function
Assessment	\$216 per job function
Instrument of Authorisation	\$328 per issuance of an instrument of authorisation
Application to vary	\$328 per application
Audit	\$47 per 15 minutes
Annual Levy	\$983 per annum

Note: These fees are correct from 1 July 2026 to 30 June 2027, but may change after this time. Further information about AO [fees and charges](#) is available on the department's website.

Scenario: When AO fees and charges are applied

Below you will find a worked example of AO fees and charges in practice.

Chris Pemsworth wishes to become a third party authorised officer. They apply through PEMS and request 2 job functions. They pay an application fee of \$328.

Chris Pemsworth's application is approved, and they request access to the eLearning. Chris pays an eLearning fee of \$130. After completing their eLearning, Chris is ready to request training in the first of their chosen job functions. They pay a training fee of \$216. After completing training, Chris requests assessment and pays an assessment fee of \$216. After being found competent at their assessment, Chris requests their instrument of authorisation and is charged an approval fee of \$328.

On 1 July, Chris is still an authorised AO. Chris is charged the annual levy of \$983, which they pay through PEMS.

Chris is settling into their role as an AO and decides to request training in the second job function. They pay a training fee of \$216. After completing training, Chris requests assessment and pays an assessment fee of \$216. Unfortunately, on this occasion, Chris is found not yet competent level 1 (NYC1) in this job function assessment. This means that Chris must attend re-training and be re-assessed as competent if they want to be authorised in this job function. Chris is charged the training fee of \$216 and the assessment fee of \$216 and is re-trained and re-assessed. On their second go, Chris is found competent at their assessment. Chris requests their instrument of authorisation in PEMS and is charged an approval fee of \$328.

Sometime later, Chris decides to add 1 more job function to their authorisation. They apply to vary their authorisation through PEMS and pay an application fee of \$328. They complete their additional eLearning and request training. They pay a training fee of \$216. After completing training, Chris requests assessment and pays an assessment fee of \$216. After being found competent at their assessment, Chris requests their instrument of authorisation and is charged an approval fee of \$328.

During their authorisation Chris is audited by the department. The audit takes 2 hours, and Chris is given an invoice for \$376, which is 8 blocks of 15 minutes charged at \$47 each. Two years after their original authorisation date, Chris Pemsworth's authorisation is due to expire. Chris requests reappointment through PEMS and is charged the approval fee of \$328.

The total cost for Chris over the 2 years of their authorisation is \$5,185.

Source: <https://www.agriculture.gov.au/biosecurity-trade/export/controlled-goods/plants-plant-products/ao>